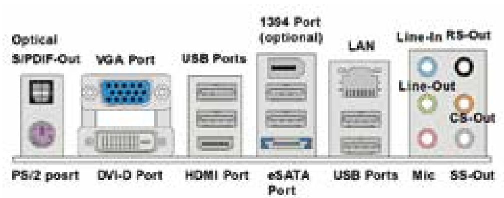
- You can customise the various settings for each component, you can disable processor features or modify memory timings or change the system clock. All these settings have to be stored somewhere and that is done by the CMOS. This CMOS chip is constantly powered by the CMOS battery which is why your specific settings remain even when you shut your PC down.

Certain features may get updates as time goes by and you then receive a BIOS update from your motherboard manufacturer's website. You then have to rewrite the BIOS chip with the new program and this is done via a process called flashing. As a golden rule, never ever flash your BIOS unless there is something wrong. The unnecessary urge to have the latest BIOS is something that users get carried away with. This is because the process is quite risky. If anything disturbs this process then by all means you shall have bricked your BIOS. Bricking is when the flash writing process is not completed successfully and the BIOS is unable to perform or even switch on. Higher-end motherboard models come with a backup BIOS chip. A recent innovation that has spread like wildfire is the UEFI BIOS which allows one to use the mouse in the BIOS screen. This has been customised to include a lot of eye candy and has made the BIOS a much more user friendly tool.

6. Backplate I/O



The backplate is the one avenue where you can connect your various peripherals (optional and essential). Your display (in case you are using the onboard graphics chip), keyboard, mouse, ethernet, USB peripherals, audio equipment etc, connect to your motherboard via the backplate. The dimensions of the backplate are standard so even if your motherboard supports a lot of connectivity options you can only fit so much into that area. Certain motherboards have buttons which trigger special functions placed on the backplate. Common among them are the Shutdown / Reset button, CMOS reset button and overclocking profiles button.

7. Headers

Whatever cannot be accommodated via the backplate is managed through headers. So your motherboard may support 12 USB 2.0 ports but your back-